

Haolang Li

Dec 3rd, 2025

Vicinity, Volume, and a Progressive Sense of Place:

Migrant Infrastructures and Everyday Practices at Dong Xuan Center

1. Introduction

Discourses under the topic of migration, sense of belonging, and community formation have been a crucial component of urban and cultural geography studies. Questions were asked regarding the survival ship, rights to space, and rights to live of minority groups in society based on egalitarian principles. Meanwhile, concerns were also suggested on the commercialization and essentialization of communities that aware us also on the danger of capital intrusion. Within this broader discussion, both existing scholarship on the area's history and a 2025 report issued by the local district indicate that the Dong Xuan Center (DXC), a market in Lichtenberg, Berlin shaped strongly by Vietnamese traditions, offers a particularly compelling site for examining the dialectical relationship between economic logics and modes of social survival. The DXC makes visible both the economic vitality that provides a hub for migrant groups' sense of belonging and the regulatory restrictions imposed by local authorities. Discussions around DXC makes it a key site for reflecting how migrant communities could negotiate existence and belonging in modern capitalist cities.

Aside from historical, political, and theoretical inquiries, this paper takes on a fresh perspective through ethnographic observation of the visible nearby. Instead of approaching the market as a static ethnic site or a poli-economic zone of interest, this paper observes the DXC as a daily infrastructure and give back the agency to members inside, including Vietnamese, Turkish, Indian, and Chinese vendors. Through ethnographic observation, this paper asks the

research question of how Vietnamese and other migrant entrepreneurs at the Dong Xuan Center negotiate their sense of belonging through embodied practices within the everyday vicinity of the community.

2. Review of the Literature

Vietnam communities in Berlin have a highly heterogeneous history. Generally, two main groups immigrated from Vietnam. The first were refugees who arrived in the Federal Republic of Germany (FRG) under the Geneva Refugee Convention after the Vietnam War (Beth & Tuckermann, 2012). The East German government, through its close relations with North Vietnam, signed an agreement that brought 70,000 Vietnamese contract workers to East Germany (Nguyễn, 2024). Around 2005, Vietnamese contract workers established the Dong Xuan Center, making it the core of Vietnamese cultural and economic life in East Germany. However, Nguyễn (2024) noted that Western boat immigrants did not visit until 2010. Immigrants at the DXC were considered loyal to socialist Vietnam. Today, segregation is less pronounced, thanks to third-wave migration and generational change.

A paper on the "Transformative power of arrival infrastructures" describes DXC as an outcome of the marginalized economic situation of Vietnamese Berliners. They faced labor market exclusion in the early 2000s (Kreichauf et al., 2020). The author identifies two types of infrastructure. One is shaped internally, by sustained social and cultural networks. The other is shaped externally, by systems of governance and economic logic (Kreichauf et al., 2020). Ethnic economies, from an external perspective, play a crucial socio-economic role. They provide employment and services within migrant networks and serve as visible sites between marginalized groups and the wider urban economy. Schmiz and Kitzmann examined immigrant

entrepreneurs as agents bridging internal and external infrastructures. Entrepreneurs create economic and social benefits by promoting their ethnicity (Schmiz & Kitzmann, 2017).

While entrepreneurial agency in such infrastructures makes minority economies visible, it also raises questions about the commodification of cultural difference. What do we really mean when discussing diversity in a society? Is it an ideology that celebrates difference and encourages speaking up, or a set of moral guidelines that promotes equity? Maybe neither answer catches the telos of this celebrated liberal concept of multiformity. As Lee (1992) warned in his essay on commodification of ethnicity, “a celebration of ethnic diversity is prone to criticism of essentialism, be it through parades or festivals as place-making activities or through branding initiatives, e.g., of Chinatowns.” The ethnic diversity is transformed into a social spectacle that’s easily commercialized. Toward the further development plan of DXC of “developing a Chinatown-style neighborhood with housing, business areas, kindergartens... (Kreichauf et al., 2020)” Local governments in Berlin react in a defensive manner, fearing the formation of a “parallel society.” In line with the Urban Development Plan for Industry and Commerce, the Lichtenberg authorities rejected DXC’s plan to transform the land use from industrial to mixed-use retail (Schmiz & Kitzmann, 2017).

At first, the link between commercialization and the essentialization of minority communities seems plausible. However, upon closer inspection, if we view diversity and mobility only through a cultural lens and ignore power and material conditions, anti-essentialism loses its force. Veronis (2007), in a study of Latin Americans in Toronto, explained that minority spaces form through experiences of 'othering' and constant engagement with difference and exclusion. This situation mirrors hardships faced by Vietnamese groups. Veronis (2007) further stated that being labeled 'Other' becomes a political identity used to fight exclusion. If we discuss

anti-essentialism without considering minority groups' living conditions, it becomes a romanticized ideal. Commercialization and the symbolization of identity are not always forms of estrangement. Instead, they may help build subjectivity and identity. Massey's essay on "a global sense of place" argues that the specificity of a place comes from the unique constellation of social relations. These relations meet at a particular location (Massey, 1991). She opposes a reactionary sense of place and believes that as time and space compress, we also need a progressive view. This vision parallels Veronis (2007), who describes the "barrio latino" and "casa" as "third spaces"—arenas where Latin Americans negotiate identity, community, and citizenship.

The literature reveals a dialectical relationship between material survival and symbolic belonging. Minority groups rely on economic participation for their livelihoods while also seeking a sense of togetherness that resists commodification. Biao Xiang (2021) describes vicinity as a reconciliation of this tension, where physical estrangement is felt, and togetherness is imagined. When experience and symbolism are divided, meaning is lost. Vicinity thus forms a site where daily encounters build social ties. Similarly, Giesecking (2015) argues that physical presence and repeated encounters create the 'volume' of urban spaces, giving depth to social relations through embodied experiences. Both concepts highlight how daily interactions spatially and socially shape communities.

This paper also draws on Yi-Fu Tuan's spatial ethics, which emphasize being with the world in a sympathetic, meaningful way. Guided by Tuan and Xiang's ideas, the analysis connects the material and emotional aspects of the Dong Xuan Center to broader questions of how people coexist. The paper argues that the DXC is a progressive space for coexistence, where social and spatial relationships interact. By focusing on everyday negotiations within the DXC,

the analysis aims to overcome the simple binary of commodification versus authenticity, showing how practices in the center shape its development.

3. Method: Descriptive Ethnography

To understand how migrant entrepreneurs at the Dong Xuan Center negotiate their sense of belonging, I combined primary and secondary sources. Primary sources consist of direct observations, mapping based on participation, sensory ethnography, the latest government documents from 2025, and casual interviews. Secondary sources include journal articles, online websites, and books.

For my personal observations, from September to December 2025, I visited the Dong Xuan center 9 times and spent a decent amount of time at each visit. I interviewed merchants and customers, mapped out DXC, and observed the surroundings while participating. Such first-person engagements are central to understanding vicinity, as conceptualized by Xiang Biao, where meaning is produced through bodily presence and everyday encounters. After each visit, I would immediately record what I observed on my phone as an audio file so that I could review it when writing. I used these techniques not only to critically observe the space but also to engage with the community, build stronger relationships, and encourage more interactions. All observations respect anonymity, and no personal data or identifying details were recorded.

Reflecting on my methodology, the combination of primary and secondary sources shows a complementary effect, largely due to my limited access to official administrative documents from DXC. In addition, because of my limited proficiency in German, I could not communicate smoothly with most Vietnamese merchants, so I relied on a trusted translator in several interactions; this aspect will be further described later. Moreover, since each visit to DXC required at least 3.5 hours, including travel time, I had to manage my daily routine and

deliberately engage with the field. I achieved this by integrating DXC into my own practical, lived needs—shopping for groceries, repairing my friend’s computer, eating, and doing my nails—which became part of my everyday life in Berlin. It is also worth noting, with reflexivity, that my positionality as a Chinese student shaped how vendors engaged with me. I was perceived primarily more as a customer rather than a researcher, which facilitated certain interactions during my visits.

4. Conceptual Framework

This paper draws upon three main concepts suggested by past scholars: progressive sense of place, volume of space, and vicinity. Through engaging with these concepts, this paper provides an analytical framework on how migrant entrepreneurs and workers at DXC negotiate a sense of belonging through everyday practices.

Following Massey’s proposition of a progressive sense of place amid modernization, I treat DXC as a place with a non-static identity, non-enclosed boundaries, and a mix of broader social relationships. This lens provides me with a sense of distributed power that is absent in a top-down unity. Instead, power emerges from DXC’s relationships with the outer world, which shapes its trading practices, internal arrangements, and diasporic stories.

Secondly, volume of space, as Gieseeking implemented in her analysis of lesbian struggles in New York City, informs my analysis of DXC as a tool for engaging with bodily presences in DXC. As volume of space captures the compound result of bodily crossing-over, essentially, how people move among DXC, the walking routes, smell, and division of spaces, it provides informative materials on analyzing bodily engagements with the community and the formation of social networks within the community.

Thirdly, the vicinity, or the scope of vision suggested by Xiang, provides the basis for my analysis of DXC as a lens for observing the surroundings from the perspectives of merchants, customers, and nearby residents. As a major unit in the middle of Lichtenberg, this paper investigates the role that DXC plays as a unique entity in the daily lives of people in the surrounding area. Through observing festivals, special commodities, and ethnic food, I treat DXC itself as a site for constructing a material sense of the nearby.

5. Case Study Description

a. Arrival at DXC: Sensory and Visual

During my first visit to DXC, instead of taking the tram that would have brought me directly to the main entrance, I followed Google Maps while riding a bike and accidentally rode into a warehouse stacked with bottled drinks. The space's stillness felt unsettling. I was unsure whether I had trespassed. Walking through the narrow aisles, I eventually found an exit that opened into the northern edge of the Dong Xuan Center.

There are seven rectangular halls in DXC, each roughly the size of half a football field and only one story high. Unlike modern malls or shopping centers, their appearance is plain and industrial. Inside each hall, the space is split into two long sections, with shops lined up in parallel rows on both sides. A narrow, straight aisle runs through the middle, connecting both entrances and leaving each business enough room for both retail activities and wholesale storage. Walking through the halls, I constantly noticed a pungent smell and kept wondering what it was. I finally figured it out later when I was getting my nails done at DXC—it was the scent of fake nail powder. It was so strong that it even overpowered the smell of food, though I eventually got



Figure A: Warehouse south of DXC. Shot by author



Figure B: Interiors. Shot by author

used to it. Feeling a bit tired after browsing the entire area, I saw businesses including restaurants, nail salons, barbershops, grocery stores, markets, and other retail shops. Among all kinds of shops, I found more guest traffic in markets and salons, and fewer in retail shops.



Figure C: Hall 1. Shot by author

Through observing the merchants and language, I found that the businesses are mostly owned by Asian, Turkish, and Arabic immigrant entrepreneurs. As for customers, the race seems mixed. From my personal observation, the guest flow is slightly higher than on weekdays, given its closure on Tuesday rather than Sunday.

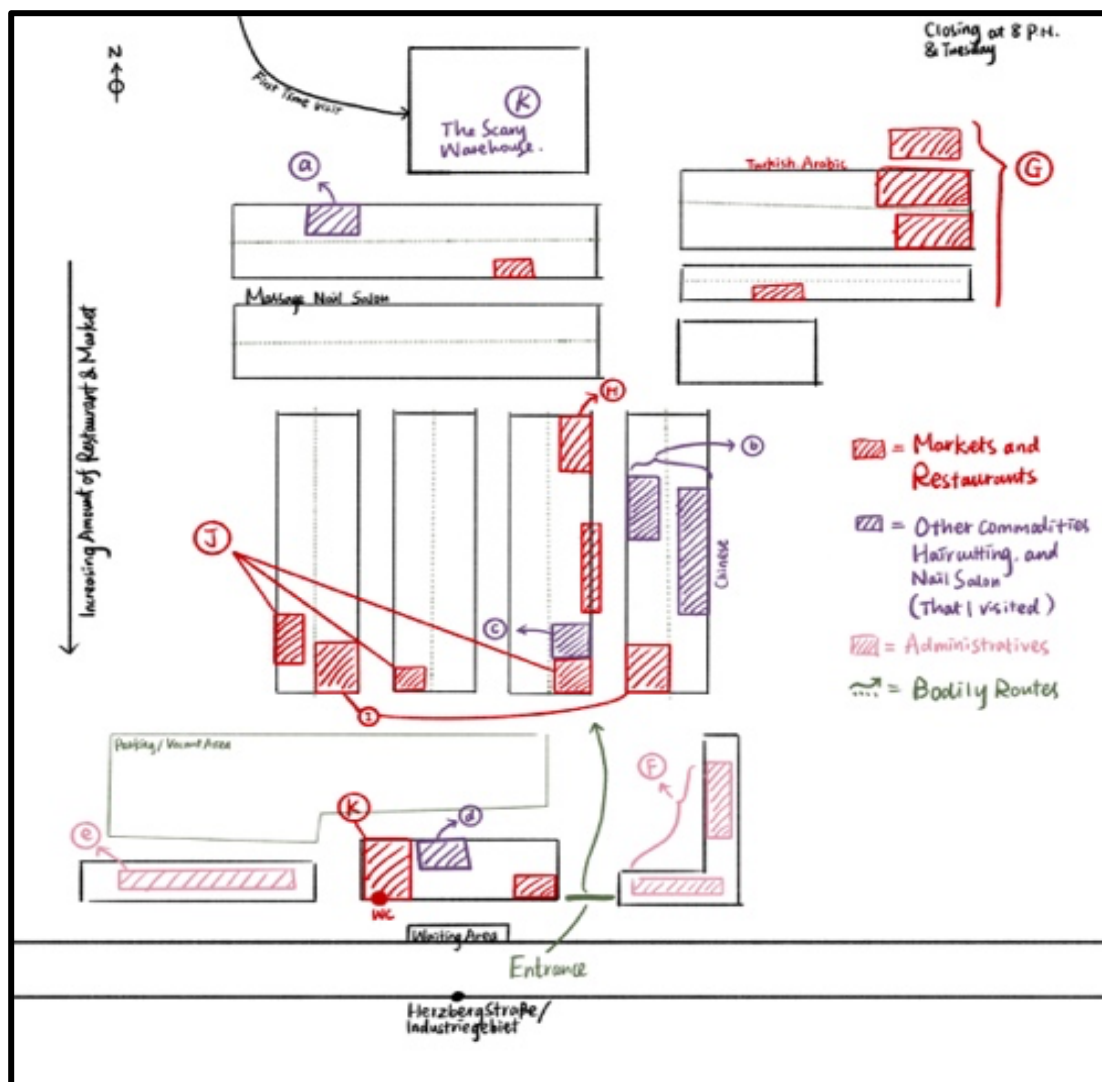


Figure D: Mapping. Mapped by author

b. Mapping of DXC

The map above illustrates my condensed observational findings from the site. As green color illustrates one's bodily route, the entrance is right beside the tram stop of Herzbergstraße with the M-line passing through. While red blocks all markets and restaurants, purple blocks indicate other businesses I visited and interacted with. While the red blocks represent all the markets and restaurants, the purple blocks indicate the other businesses I visited and interacted with. When reading the map vertically from top to bottom, a pattern emerges: the number of red blocks increases, suggesting a preference for being located closer to the entrance and therefore better guest flow. Also, by labeling different shops and areas alphabetically, I can more easily locate and refer to them when describing my participation scheme.

c. Participating in DXC

This descriptive section focuses on subjective participation in DXC. By engaging with the site through practical routines as a resident of Lichtenberg, I seek to understand the space from within, through the embodied perspective of someone who shops, repairs, and eats.

First, I had long wanted to break my nail-biting habit, so I decided it was time to get a manicure. DXC offers plenty of choices that are cheap and professional compared to others. I went to the shop "a" and tried to communicate my demands, but failed due to my lack of proficiency in German. Amazingly, when the Vietnamese receptionist realized I spoke Chinese, she immediately switched to Chinese. Later, I learned that this was because she had spent some time studying at a university in Hong Kong. The manicure costs only 25 euros. Once the work officially began, something unexpected happened: all the staff, including the owner, gathered around me with curiosity. In a brief exchange, I learned the reason: they had never seen a man get his nails done. This surprised me. In Berlin, it is common for men to paint their nails or get

manicures, especially in queer-friendly districts. Their surprise made visible the cultural assumptions about ideas about gender, presentation, and norms. Moments later, their comments, laughter, and gentle teasing folded me into their social world. I learned from the receptionist, my gatekeeper, about the site's ethnic distribution. I was told that, except for the businesses run by Vietnamese people, the two halls at the northeastern corner are mostly dominated by Turkish and Arabic businesses (area “G”), and the one labeled area “B” is a cluster of Chinese vendors.

Following her directions, I want to visit Area B during my next visit and stop at a shop that sells watches. The owner, originally from Wenzhou, imports the goods from China and distributes them across Europe. Through an informal interview, I asked the owner some questions regarding her personal and social life. Here are five key takeaways I excerpted from our conversation:

- “My monthly rent is cheap, only about 1,800 euros. Way cheaper compared to the rents in central Berlin.”
- “The center’s advertising helped my business a lot. The Vietnamese owner’s daughter and son have taken over running the place. They did a lot of online advertising.”
- “Doing retail here is tough since thieves come almost every day to steal my watches. We’ve called the police before, but generally it’s useless.”
- “My neighbors and I get along well, if we don’t sell the same stuff. (laughter)”
- “We Chinese mostly stick together. We play mahjong, and we have a Dong Xuan Center group chat on WeChat.” (Translated from Chinese dialogue)

The owner was nice to me. We exchanged contact, and she even invited me to a mahjong night, but unfortunately, I did not have the chance to join. Furthermore, I visited two other Chinese vendors whose views on their business conditions were noticeably less optimistic. One

of them complained that she is forced to sell goods at very low prices and can barely make a living. One possible explanation for this stark contrast lies in the type of goods they sell. The vendor who reported barely making a living primarily deals in wholesale clothing: items that appeared old-fashioned and low-priced. From this perspective, the struggle may not simply stem from market saturation, but also from the need for merchandise to adapt to shifting trends and consumer preferences.



Figure E: Women's day. Shot by author

During my subsequent visits to DXC, I came across several gatherings organized by the local Vietnamese community. On October 20th, I walked past a restaurant (area “H”) and noticed several women dressed in ethnic clothing with red flowers and bandanas as decorations. Intrigued, I walked inside and tried to learn about the event from a waiter using Google



Figure F: Google Translation. Shot by author

Translate. I learned that it was a celebration for “Vietnamese Women’s Day.” Inside, nearly every table was filled with women dining together, while men stood nearby holding bouquets of flowers, waiting to present them. The atmosphere was warm, festive, and intimate. Unfortunately, because the banquet was fully booked in advance, I was unable to join the celebration myself.

Another ceremonial space I encountered was the banquet hall where a wedding was taking place. It was again a coincidental encounter, this time at area “d”, where a relatively more modern architecture takes place. Inside, the hall was filled with bright lights, floral decorations, and round tables arranged in the familiar style of East and Southeast Asian wedding banquets.



Figure G: Wedding inside a hall. Shot by author

d. DXC and Restrictions from Local Government

The newest report published by the Lichtenberg district (Bezirksamt Lichtenberg von Berlin, 2025) on the commercial use of land aligns with the paper by Schmiz and Kitzmann (2017). It claimed that DXC is considered a “special center (Sonderzentrum)” that “no further retail growth shall occur (kein Einzelhandelswachstum erfolgen).” The reason for its classification as a “special center,” as the report explains, is that the Dong Xuan Center is a predominantly Asian-oriented commercial and service location. And due to the “highly specialized assortment, wholesale orientation, and regionally oriented customer base, ” it disqualifies it from fulfilling the everyday needs of nearby residents. (Bezirksamt Lichtenberg von Berlin, 2025)” In short, in 2025, the DXC is approached by local authorities with a conservative attitude, thereby placing the burden of negotiation and survival largely on the migrant entrepreneurs who inhabit it.

6. Discussion

While the Lichtenberg retail plan argues that the DXC’s “highly specialized” product range prevents it from serving local everyday needs, my ethnographic observations reveal a different lived reality. The district fails to acknowledge the everyday relational infrastructures of survival ships that operate through migrant economies, generating a “place of sense” in the broader neighborhood. In the discussion section, two main perspectives will be considered, one from within, including the business owners and cultural practitioners, and the other from without, including travelers and nearby residents.

Firstly, DXC itself demonstrates a basic “place of sense” through its daily use and existence. According to Kreichauf et al. (2020), DXC, as a “basic infrastructure,” empowers migrants by enabling arrival, belonging, mobility, and economic activity. Through repeated

trading practices, DXC accumulates agency by circulating in Berlin's discourse as a node of cultural presence, which attracts a wide range of visitors.

Secondly, the "sense of place" then emerges from relational practices. As an import and export center in Europe for Asian goods, DXC serves as the hub for transnational trade (Kreichauf et al., 2020). My encounters with Chinese and Vietnamese entrepreneurs reveal their business practices, including importing from their homeland and exporting around Europe. This situates DXC in a web of global connections. This relationality resonates with Massey's argument that places are "constructed out of social relations...meeting and weaving together at a particular locus (Massey, 1991)." DXC embodies precisely such a place. From merchants selling the newest version of Labubu to those who provide nail materials and services across Europe, DXC's meaning emerges not solely from "ethnic character" but from its everyday function as a relational infrastructure that connects Berlin and Europe to wider Asian worlds. The relational value is also generated from within, through, for example, every merchant's psychological mapping of DXC, togetherness between Chinese merchants and their community, and the mutual struggle against thieves.

Thirdly, the volume of space that pronounces the immigrant identity is generated through cultural practices. Gieseking's idea of volume emphasizes bodily movements, gathering, and leaving traces in space. The celebrations I encountered, including Vietnamese Women's Day at a restaurant and a wedding banquet, accumulate in spatial memory. DXC thus becomes a site of cultural reproduction that allows migrant communities to continuously remake their identities through everyday rituals and shared practices. In addition, the smell of nail polish also adds a layer to its unique, sensational character. Therefore, DXC's volume is produced by the very communities that inhabit it, making the site more than just a marketplace.

By framing the analysis externally, DXC creates a sense of community for residents. Contrary to the district's classification of the center as a special provider of cultural goods with little relevance to everyday demand, my observations suggest otherwise. What I encountered are affordable services, including nail salons, hairdressers, and phone and computer repair shops. They met my practical needs during fieldwork and are likely to be necessary for the daily routines of nearby residents. In this sense, DXC participates in what Xiang Biao (2021) calls vicinity. DXC thus becomes a site for showing how commercial interests and relational connections can co-exist. Analyzing from this angle, one cannot ignore the broader commercial considerations behind the government's restrictive stance toward DXC: the competition between DXC and other retail centers in Lichtenberg, which is never explicitly addressed in planning documents but could nevertheless affect policy decisions. This becomes one of the future research possibilities.

7. Conclusion

Taken together, the findings from this paper suggest that the Dong Xuan Center functions less as a bounded, paralleled ethnic enclave than as an infrastructure in which material survival, spatial practice, and symbolic belonging are continuously generated. In this paper, it is argued that, rather than confirming a duality between commodification and authenticity, everyday interactions within DXC demonstrate how migrant entrepreneurs actively constitute a relational sense of place through their embodied presence. In this light, the center's significance lies not only in its economic role but in its capacity to generate a lived spatial ethic that foregrounds the ongoing production of social ties within the constraints of contemporary urban governance in Berlin.

Word Count

3738 words excluding titles, word count, and citation.

Use of AI

For the use of AI, I used ChatGPT to help me translate and explain the document “Entwurf Zentren- und Einzelhandelskonzept für den Bezirk Lichtenberg von Berlin – Fortschreibung 2025” published on “mein.berlin.de.” I used Grammarly to fix my language.

Citation

Geschichte, Arbeit und Alltag vietnamesischer Migrant_innen. In K. N. Ha (Hrsg.), *Asiatische Deutsche. Vietnamese Diaspora and Beyond* (Pp 99–117). Hamburg, Berlin: Assoziation A. (o.D.). -.

Giesecking, J. J. (2015). Crossing over into neighbourhoods of the body: urban territories, borders and lesbian-queer bodies in New York City. *Area*, 48(3), 262–270.
<https://doi.org/10.1111/area.12147>

Kreichauf, R., Rosenberger, O. & Strobel, P. (2020). The Transformative Power of Urban Arrival Infrastructures: Berlin’s Refugio and Dong Xuan Center. *Urban Planning*, 5(3), 44–54. <https://doi.org/10.17645/up.v5i3.2897>

Lee, D. O. (1992). Commodification of Ethnicity. *Urban Affairs Quarterly*, 28(2), 258–275.
<https://doi.org/10.1177/004208169202800204>

Massey, D. (1991). A Global Sense of Place. -, 146–156.
<https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203931950-45>

Nguyễn, N. H. C. (2024). *Routledge Handbook of the Vietnamese Diaspora*. In Routledge eBooks. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003036104>

- Schmiz, A. & Kitzmann, R. (2017). Negotiating an Asiatown in Berlin: Ethnic diversity in urban planning. *Cities*, 70, 1–10. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cities.2017.06.001>
- Tuan, Y. (2014). *Romantic Geography: In Search of the Sublime Landscape*.
<https://muse.jhu.edu/chapter/992344/pdf>
- Veronis, L. (2007). Strategic spatial essentialism: Latin Americans' real and imagined geographies of belonging in Toronto. *Social & Cultural Geography*, 8(3), 455–473.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/14649360701488997>
- Xiang, B. (2021). The nearby: A scope of seeing. *Journal Of Contemporary Chinese Art*, 8(2), 147–165. https://doi.org/10.1386/jcca_00042_1
- Bezirksamt Lichtenberg von Berlin. (2025). Entwurf des Zentren- und Einzelhandelskonzepts für den Bezirk Lichtenberg in Berlin – Fortschreibung 2025 [Draft centers-and-retail concept for the district of Lichtenberg, Berlin – 2025 update]. <https://www.berlin.de/>